

Austria

Studying in Austria as a Non-EU Student: Complete Visa & Residence Permit Guide

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1. Study Courses That Qualify

Not every course in Austria qualifies you for a long-term study permit. According to OeAD, the official "Residence Permit – Student" is intended for nationals of third countries who have been admitted to study at a higher education institution in Austria, and it covers: [OeAD-GmbH](#)

- Full degree programmes ("ordentliches Studium") at a university, Fachhochschule (university of applied sciences), accredited private university, or teacher-training college
- Non-degree certificate programmes with at least 40 ECTS credits, as long as the course isn't purely a language course [OeAD-GmbH](#)
- University Preparation Programmes for supplementary entrance exams
- Programmes to get a foreign degree recognized in Austria ("Nostrifizierung")

Importantly, non-degree programme studies which only involve attending individual courses are generally not sufficient to get this permit — so a casual continuing-education course or standalone seminar usually won't qualify you for the long-stay route. For very short stays (language courses, summer schools under 90 days), the relevant document is a short-stay Schengen visa, not the residence permit. [OeAD-GmbH](#)

2. Booking an Embassy Appointment

Applications normally go through the competent Austrian representative authority (embassy, consulate with power to issue visa) in the student's country of residence. In practice: [OeAD-GmbH](#)

- You book an appointment online via the embassy/consulate's official booking portal (each Austrian embassy has its own system).
- Appointments should be booked well in advance — some posts, like the embassy in certain South Asian countries, fill up months ahead for "Student" slots.
- It's recommended to apply 4–6 months before your intended start date to allow time for both the appointment and processing.
- If you're from a country exempt from Austrian visa requirements, you may instead be able to apply directly at the local residence authority inside Austria after entry — though OeAD recommends applying from abroad regardless, to avoid risking an overstay if processing runs long.

3. Steps to Apply for a Study Visa

The process generally runs like this:

1. **Get your university admission letter** ("Zulassungsbescheid") first — you can't apply without it.
2. **Gather documents** (see Q4/Q5 below) and have foreign documents legalised/apostilled and translated into German.
3. **Book and attend an embassy/consulate appointment** in your home country, applying in person.

4. **Wait for the decision.** The decision period for the "Residence Permit-Student" is 90 days, but is extended by a further 90 days if additional documents need to be submitted. [OeAD-GmbH](#)
5. **Apply for Visa D** once approved — you have three months to apply for a visa D to collect the residence title, and the representative authority will issue the Visa D for a validity period of four months. [OeAD-GmbH](#)
6. **Travel to Austria** and collect your physical residence permit card, generally within 6 months of the approval notification.
7. **Register your address** at the local Meldeamt within 3 working days of arrival.

Documents needed (detailed in Q4) include passport, photo, proof of funds, accommodation proof, health insurance, admission letter, and a police clearance certificate. **Total typical timeline:** allow 4–6 months overall once you include legalisation, the embassy appointment, and the up-to-180-day decision window.

4. Documents Needed

Per the official checklist, you'll need:

- Valid passport (copy of all pages for first-time applications)
- Passport photo (ICAO standard, color, 3.5 × 4.5 cm, under 6 months old)
- Proof of sufficient financial means for 12 months in advance (see Q5)
- Proof of the source of those funds (bank statements, scholarship letters, parental sponsorship declarations, etc.)
- Declaration of regular expenses (loans, maintenance obligations)
- Proof of accommodation in Austria for at least 3 months
- Proof of comprehensive health insurance
- University letter of admission ("Zulassungsbescheid")
- Police clearance certificate, no older than 3 months, legalised and translated

For renewals, you'd instead submit proof of academic progress, continuing enrollment confirmation, and your study record.

5. Money Requirements (2026 figures)

OeAD lists the current minimums as:

- Students under 24 years of age: EUR 722.58/month [OeAD-GmbH](#)
- Students as of the age of 24: EUR 1,308.39/month [OeAD-GmbH](#)
- Couples: EUR 2,064.12/month for both [OeAD-GmbH](#)
- For each child additionally: EUR 201.88/month [OeAD-GmbH](#)

You have to prove these funds for twelve months in advance, and the money has to be in a (foreign) savings book or (foreign) bank account that must bear the applicant's name and be accessible from Austria. Scholarships, traveller's cheques, or a third-party guarantee declaration ("Haftungserklärung") from someone resident in the EU are also accepted alternatives. If the costs

for accommodation exceed EUR 386.43/month, you have to prove additional funds. [OeAD-GmbH + 2](#)

6. Applying for the Residence Permit After Arrival

If you entered on Visa D, here's what happens on the ground:

- Register your address with the local Meldeamt (registration office) within 3 working days of finding accommodation — this isn't required if you're in short-term tourist accommodation for under 2 months.
- *Correction: per OeAD's official guidance, the three-working-day clock starts on your date of arrival in Austria, not on the date you find or move into accommodation: "You have to register within three working days of arrival in Austria with the registration office at your place of residence." The tourist-accommodation exemption (under 2 months) is correctly stated. Source: OeAD (oead.at), "Residence Permit – Student" checklist.*
- Collect your residence permit card. To do this you need to show your residence registration ("Meldezettel") and your final university admission confirmation. If you stated you'd take out student insurance after arrival, you also need to bring that confirmation from the Austrian health insurer (ÖGK).
- The permit is issued in credit card format with photograph and also serves as an ID document, valid for up to 12 months. OeAD-GmbH

7. Working While Studying

Yes — with restrictions. Holders of a "Residence Permit – Student" will be able to get a work permit for working for up to 20 hours/week. This involves small-scale employment as well. This permit will be granted without a labour market check. However, an occupation that is subject to the Act Governing Employment of Foreign Nationals may only be carried out with a work permit, and the employer has to apply for this work permit at the Public Employment Service (AMS) before the employee takes up the job — so the application burden is actually on your employer, not you.

- Some sources note bachelor's students may be capped lower (10 hours) versus master's/PhD students (20 hours), so it's worth confirming with your specific institution or the AMS, as this can vary by permit subtype. OeAD-GmbH
- *Correction: this bachelor's/master's split is outdated. Current official guidance no longer distinguishes by degree level: all holders of a "Residence Permit – Student" (bachelor's, master's, or doctoral) may get a work permit for up to 20 hours/week without a labour market check. Sources: OeAD (oead.at); Austrian Federal Ministry of the Interior / migration.gv.at; oesterreich.gv.at.*

8. Renewing the Residence Permit

If your studies run longer than a year:

- You have to apply for a renewal of your residence permit at the competent residence authority in Austria before your residence permit expires; however, at the earliest three months before expiry of the permit. [OeAD-GmbH](#)
- Until a decision about your application for a renewal is taken you are considered to be lawfully resident in Austria, even if your current residence permit expires in the meantime — so don't panic if the decision takes a while, as long as you applied on time. [OeAD-GmbH](#)

- You'll need to show confirmation of your continuing university enrolment, your record of studies, as well as proof of academic success in the scope of eight semester hours per academic year or 16 ECTS credits per academic year. [OeAD-GmbH](#)
- If you need to travel abroad while the renewal is pending and your old permit has expired, you can request a "Notvignette," valid for 3 months, which lets you re-enter — but it can only be applied for once per renewal procedure. [OeAD-GmbH](#)[OeAD-GmbH](#)

9. Changing to a Work Permit After Graduation

Yes, this is possible. Students who have completed their studies holding a "Residence Permit – Student" may apply for a renewal of the permit for another 12 months to look for a job or set up a business. After that job-seeking year, you can change it for example to a "Red-White-Red Card" (e.g. for university graduates), a "Settlement Permit – Researcher", a "Blue Card EU" or a residence title "Family member". A change to a "Settlement Permit – Special Cases of Gainful Employment" may also be possible if the desired employment corresponds to the level of the completed degree. [OeAD-GmbH + 2](#)

10. Official Information Sources

The two key official sources are:

- **OeAD** (Austria's Agency for Education and Internationalisation) — [oead.at](#) — the most student-friendly official portal, with detailed checklists in English.
- **Austrian Federal Ministry / MA35 (in Vienna)** — handles the actual residence permit decisions; other provinces use the local Bezirkshauptmannschaft (BH).
- Your nearest **Austrian embassy or consulate** website for visa application procedures specific to your country.

11. Where to Download Application Forms

Official application forms are available through:

- The OeAD website's residence permit pages (links to the relevant form explanations)
- The website of the specific Austrian embassy/consulate where you're applying (most post the residence permit application form as a downloadable PDF)
- MA35's website if you're applying or renewing from within Vienna

I'd recommend going through your specific embassy's official site directly, since form versions can be updated.

12. Common Mistakes Students Make

Based on the official guidance and how the process typically trips people up:

Applying too late is probably the single biggest issue — given the 90-to-180-day decision window plus document legalisation time, starting less than 4-5 months before your intended arrival is risky. Another frequent problem is underestimating document legalisation: foreign documents like police clearance certificates need to be legalised/apostilled and then translated into German by a certified translator, and this step alone can take weeks depending on the issuing country. People also sometimes submit financial proof that doesn't meet the strict "name on account, accessible from Austria" rule, or forget that accommodation costs above €386.43/month require proving extra funds beyond the base minimum. Finally, some students assume any course or enrollment

qualifies them for the residence permit, when in fact OeAD explicitly excludes non-degree programmes involving only individual course attendance.

One caveat worth flagging: immigration fees and minimum income thresholds in Austria are adjusted periodically (often annually), so it's worth double-checking exact euro figures on the OeAD site or with your embassy close to your actual application date.

Gemini

1. Study Courses

To apply for a student visa or student residence permit in Austria, you must be admitted as a regular or non-regular student to a recognized Austrian educational institution. Eligible courses include:

- **Degree Programs:** Full-time Bachelor's, Master's, or PhD programs at public universities, private universities, or Universities of Applied Sciences (*Fachhochschulen*).
- **University Preparation Programs:** Courses (*Vorstudienlehrgang*) designed to prepare you for university supplementary exams (e.g., German language or core subjects) before starting a degree program, provided you have a conditional letter of admission.
- **Accredited Certificate Courses:** Non-degree university certificate courses (*Universitätslehrgang*) that comprise at least 40 ECTS credits and are not structured purely as language courses.

2. Embassy Appointment

To book an appointment to apply for your study visa or residence permit:

1. Locate the competent **Austrian Embassy or Consulate-General (BMEIA)** in your home country or country of legal residence.
2. Visit their official website. Most Austrian embassies handle appointments through an online booking portal (such as *Appointment-Plus* or a localized scheduling system).
3. Book well in advance. Appointment slots can be limited, especially during peak periods (June to September).

3. & 4. Applying for a Study Visa & Documents Needed

If you plan to study in Austria for **up to 6 months**, you apply for a **Visa D**. If your studies last **longer than 6 months**, you must apply for a **Residence Permit – Student** (*Aufenthaltsbewilligung – Student*).

How to Apply

Applications for the residence permit are typically submitted **in person** at the Austrian Embassy in your home country. The embassy forwards the application to the local immigration authority in Austria (e.g., MA35 in Vienna) for processing.

Processing Time

- **Visa D:** Typically **15 to 45 days**.
- **Residence Permit – Student:** Usually takes **1 to 3 months**, but it can take longer depending on the volume of applications and completeness of documents. It is highly recommended to apply 3–4 months before your intended departure.

Checklist of Required Documents

All documents must be submitted in the original alongside a photocopy. Documents not written in German or English must be translated by a certified translator and legally authenticated (Apostille or legalization) if required.

- Fully completed and signed **Application Form**.
- Valid **Passport** (must have at least two blank pages and be valid for at least 3 months beyond your planned departure).
- Recent **Passport Photograph** (ICAO standard, 3.5 x 4.5 cm, not older than 6 months).
- **Birth Certificate**.
- **Police Clearance Certificate / Certificate of Good Conduct** from your home country (not older than 3 months).
- **Letter of Admission** (*Zulassungsbescheid*) from the Austrian university or college.
- **Proof of Secure Accommodation** for at least 3 months (e.g., student dorm contract, rental lease, or accommodation agreement).
- **Proof of Health Insurance** providing comprehensive coverage in Austria (minimum coverage of €30,000).
- **Proof of Sufficient Financial Means** (see Section 5).

5. Money Requirements

You must prove you can cover your living expenses for the first 12 months in advance. The official legal thresholds require the following monthly funds:

Important Note on Accommodation: If your monthly rent/accommodation costs exceed **€386.43**, you must prove *additional* funds equivalent to the amount exceeding this limit. You must also account for any necessary health insurance premium costs.

Category	Monthly fund requirement
Students under 24 years old	€722.58 / month
Students 24 years old and older	€1,308.39 / month
Couples	€2,064.12 / month (total)

Category	Monthly Fund Requirement	Students under 24 years old	€722.58 / month	Students 24 years old and older
		€1,308.39 / month	Couples	€2,064.12 / month (total)

Accepted Proof of Funds:

- An Austrian or international bank account accessible from Austria showing the total amount (€8,670+ or €15,700+ depending on your age).
- Proof of origin of funds (e.g., your parents' last 6 months of bank statements and an employment contract/pay slips, or proof of an inheritance/property sale).
- A formal declaration of guarantee (*Haftungserklärung*) from a person residing legally in the EU.
- A confirmation of an official scholarship award.

6. Residence Permit (After Arrival)

If you applied for a Residence Permit - Student from your home country, you will be issued a 4-month Visa D to enter Austria to pick up your permit. Once you land:

- **Meldezettel (Address Registration):** You must register your residential address at the local registration office (Meldeamt) within 3 business days of moving into your housing.
- **Pick up the Permit:** Visit the local immigration office (the Magistrat or Bezirkshauptmannschaft-for example, MA35 in Vienna) to submit your fingerprints, **pay the issuance fee (approx. €160 total for application and issuance)**, and collect your physical biometric Residence Permit card.
- **Correction:** As of 2026, the residence permit application fee is €218 (a single fee covering processing and issuance of the card). Source: [oesterreich.gv.at / migration.gv.at](https://oesterreich.gv.at/migration.gv.at)

7. Working While Studying

Yes, non-EU students holding a valid Residence Permit - Student are legally permitted to work part-time alongside their studies.

- **Hour Limits:** You are allowed to work up to 20 hours per week.
- **Work Permit Requirement:** You cannot just start working. Your employer must apply for a Work Permit (Beschäftigungsbewilligung) from the Austrian Public Employment Service (AMS) on your behalf before your first day.
- The AMS usually issues this permit **within 3 to 6 weeks** without requiring a labor market test, provided you do not exceed the 20-hour weekly threshold.
- **Correction:** According to oead.at (workinaustria.com citing AMS), the AMS issues the work permit in approximately 4 to 6 weeks, not 3 to 6 weeks. Source: oead.at

8. Renewing the Residence Permit

Your *Residence Permit – Student* is typically issued for 12 months at a time. To renew it:

- **When to apply:** You must submit your renewal application **before your current permit expires**, at the earliest 3 months before the expiration date.
- **Where to apply:** At the local immigration authority within Austria (not at the embassy).
- **Key Academic Requirement:** You must submit proof of successful study progress (*Studienerfolg*). This means you must have completed at least **16 ECTS credits** (or 8 semester hours) of coursework or examinations during the previous academic year.

9. Changing to a Work Permit (After Graduation)

Austria has an advantageous system for retaining international talent. Upon graduating from an Austrian higher education institution:

1. **Job-Seeker Extension:** You can extend your student residence permit for up to **12 months** post-graduation specifically to find a job or set up a business matching your qualification level.

2. **Red-White-Red (RWR) Card:** Once you receive a concrete job offer that matches your degree level, you can transition to a **Red-White-Red Card for Graduates** (*Rot-Weiß-Rot – Karte für StudienabsolventInnen*).
 - a. **The Advantage:** For graduates of Austrian universities, there is **no point system evaluation** and **no labor market test** required. You only need to fulfill the standard minimum salary offered on the open market for the role, and the job must match your academic profile.

10. & 11. Official Information & Application Forms

For legal accuracy and direct downloads of paperwork, utilize these authoritative resources:

- **OeAD (Austrian Agency for Education and Internationalisation):** The most exhaustive and up-to-date informational portal for incoming students.
 - Website: oead.at
- **BMEIA (Federal Ministry for European and International Affairs):** For embassy locations, booking portals, and visa application details.
 - Website: bmeia.gv.at
- **Official Austrian Government Portal:** Provides legal structural overviews and links to downloadable PDF forms for visas and residence permits.
 - Website: oesterreich.gv.at

12. Tips for Students: Common Mistakes to Avoid

- **Missing the Renewal Deadline:** Applying even one day after your residence permit expires turns your application into a "first-time" request, meaning you may legally have to leave Austria and start over at the embassy in your home country.
- **Unclear Financial Trail:** Simply having the lump sum in an account is often not enough. Austrian authorities heavily scrutinize the *origin* of the funds. Failing to provide parents' pay slips, tax filings, or clear statements explaining where the cash came from causes heavy processing delays.
- **Failing the ECTS Threshold:** Keep track of your academic performance. If you fail to achieve the required 16 ECTS credits in a year without a severe, documented justification (like a chronic medical emergency), your renewal will be denied.
- **Incorrect Document Legalization:** Submitting certificates or police records without the required Apostille stamp or diplomatic legalization from your home country will result in the documents being rejected, halting your application timeline entirely.